

slackware13

Is it Really Worthy of the 21st Century?

The latest version of the oldest surviving GNU/Linux distro comes with updates galore, including a KDE4 desktop and ext4 filesystem. It perhaps even has everything for a geek. However, whether it makes the cut for a typical desktop user is the real question.

Slackware is old. No really, it's OLD! If you're used to the likes of Ubuntu or any of the other modern GNU/Linux systems, setting up Slackware would seem like you're back in the early 90s.

Some will argue that Ubuntu and the rest that try to make life easier for desktop users don't give *that* fine-grained control over the way you set up your system. Why should a distro try to make choices on your behalf? By configuring your system from the bottom up, you'd ultimately learn the internals.

Does it help? Yes, it does. Immensely! Does everyone have the time and inclination? NO!

Whatever said and done, the majority of those who use computers want to get on

with their work—most don't have the time to peek into the innards of an OS. So, if you belong to this category, you're probably better off without Slackware.

However, Slackware 13 has one surprise in its bag—the desktop somehow looks pretty modern, and works out-of-the-box. Yes, KDE4 has finally infected the conservative Slackware developer(s). Pat Volkerding writes in the release notes, "I'm using it on all my own machines (including an Intel Atom with compositing enabled), and I've really fallen in love with it once I got used to it. The tools are integrated better with the desktop, Qt4 seems to be a faster and more stable platform, and nearly everything that was available for KDE3 has been ported to KDE4 and works great."